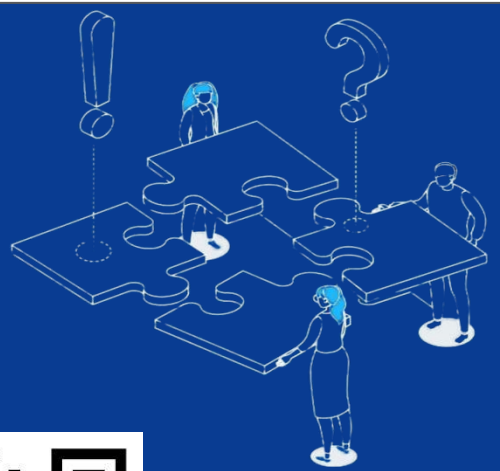
The Future of NLP Needs Ethical Considerations: An Interactive Tutorial for Researchers and Students



Xi Ai, Vamshi Krishna Bonagiri, Monojit Choudhury, Abdoul Jalil Djiberou Mahamadou, Esther Gan, Zhijing Jin, Min-Yen Kan, Seunghun J. Lee, Yisong Miao, Margot Mieskes, Aurélie Névéol, Yajing Yang

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https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

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Yajing Yang

National University
Of Singapore, *Singapore*

QR Access to Tutorial Materials



Activity Slide Deck

https://soc-n.us/261109-ethics-tutorial-activity



Presentation Deck

https://soc-n.us/261109-ethics-tutorial-slides

(you are here)

https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

Agenda for today

Time	Activity	Presenters
9:00–9:10	Introductions and Kickoff	Min
9:10–9:40	Ethics: Philosophical Bases	Yajing, Esther, Yisong
9:40–10:05	Environmental and Societal Impacts	Margot, Aurélie
10:05–10:30	Team Discussion	*All Participants*
10:30–11:00	☕ *Break* ☕	
11:00–11:40	Team Presentation	*All Participants*
11:40–11:50	Ethical Consideration Sections in ACL Venues	Yisong
11:50–12:20	Language Representation and Multilingual Bias	Vamshi, Barid, Seunghun
12:20–12:30	Closing	

https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

Introduction and Pre-tutorial Survey

Min-Yen Kan
National University of Singapore

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Ethics:
Philosophical Bases

Esther Gan, Yajing Yang, Yisong Miao
National University of Singapore

Note

The slides for this portion of the tutorial are adapted from the original slides by Karën Fort and Fanny Ducel, used by permission. The original version is available here:

https://soc-n.us/261109-ethics-slides-source

Why should you care?

- because you are a citizen, who lives in this world
- because ethical products sell better [Spiekermann, 2015] (?)
- because if you don't as NLP specialists, others with less knowledge will

A Question of Time

The Question Behind

Virtue Ethics

Deontological (duty) Ethics

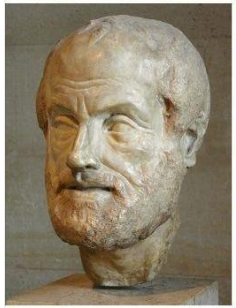
Utilitarianism

Back to NLP

To finish

A very old question (the oldest?) in a brave new world





From Lysippe — Eric Gaba (User:Sting),

July 2005., CC BY-SA 2.5

Ethics is a domain from…



What discipline/domain thinks a lot about ethics?



Is (the outcome of) science necessarily good?

Are there things that are possible to do that we agree we should not?



(c) https://www.starwars.com/databank/clone-troopers

Is (the way we do) science necessarily good?

Are there things that are possible to do that we agree we should not?

The Nuremberg Code

originated before, but finalized during “the Doctors’ Trial” (1947)

The report includes 3 main principles:

- Respect of the subject:
  - informed consent
- Beneficience:
  - favorable risks/benefits balance
- Justice:
  - fair selection of the subjects



Unit 731

Imperial Japanese Army, Pingfang (near Harbin, China), 1930s–1945



The Belmont Report [Bel, 1979]

originated from “Tuskegee Syphilis Experiment” (1932-1972)

The report includes 3 main principles:

- Respect of the subject:
  - informed consent
- Beneficience:
  - favorable risks/benefits balance
- Justice:
  - fair selection of the subjects



A Question of Time

The Question Behind

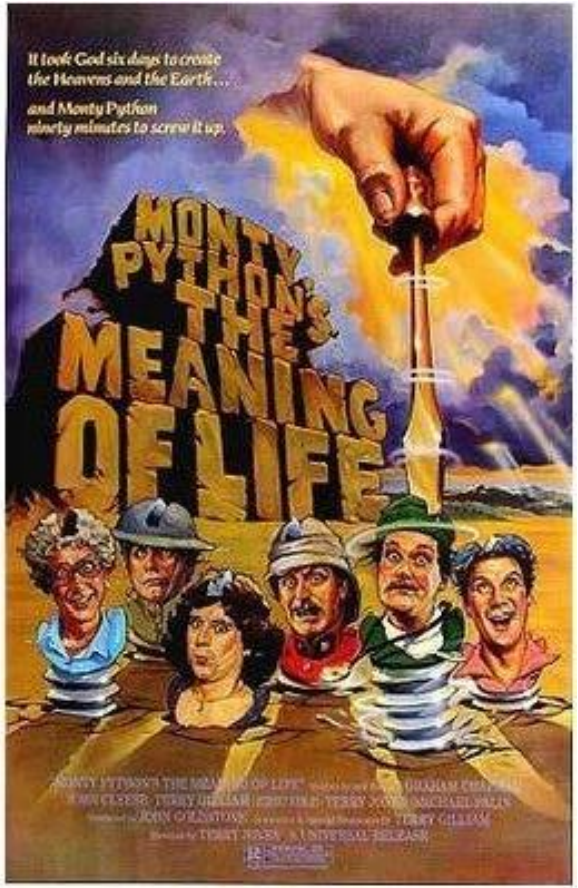
Virtue Ethics

Deontological (duty) Ethics

Utilitarianism

Back to NLP

To finish



(c) 1983 Universal City Studios. All rights reserved.

What is a good life?



How humans should best live (to achieve this **good** life)

A Question of Time

The Question Behind

Virtue Ethics

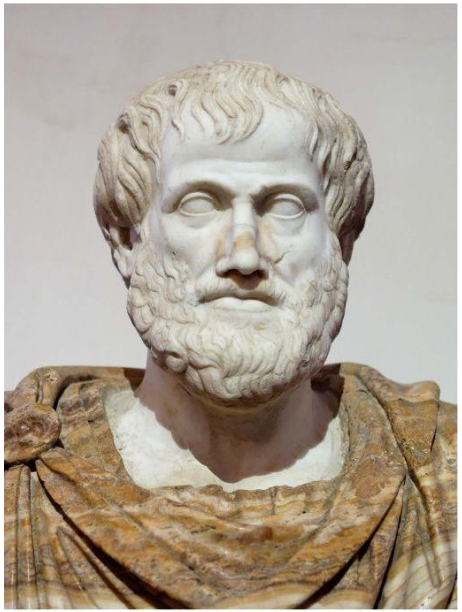
Deontological (duty) Ethics

Utilitarianism

Back to NLP

To finish

Aristotle (384–322 BC) (亚里士多德 · 美德伦理)



After Lysippos - Jastrow (2006)

What kind of person are you becoming?

NLP: What culture and values does this LLM cultivate?

Work on ethics

Nicomachean Ethics

Ethics is about action: What kind of person do you want to be?

Goal: Always choose to do what is good.

How to achieve:

- Practice doing good everyday
- Spend time with good people

The golden rule: Find the middle ground – not to the extremes

A Question of Time

The Question Behind

Virtue Ethics

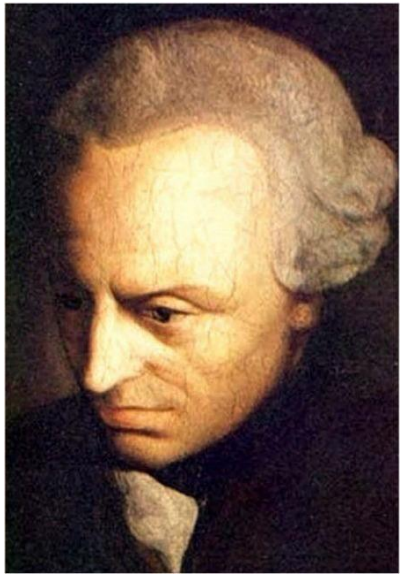
Deontological (duty) Ethics

Utilitarianism

Back to NLP

To finish

Immanuel Kant (1724-1804) (康德 · 义务论)



What rules must never be broken regardless of the outcome?

NLP: Enforcing non-negotiable safety guardrails and privacy rights, no matter how useful it is to the model.

Work on ethics

Critique of Pure Reason
Critique of Practical Reason

The Imperative of the Practical Reason

Goal: Do what is inherently right out of duty, not because of feelings, impulses, or external rewards.

How to achieve:

- Use reason to control your desires rather than being controlled by short-term wants
- Treat all human beings with inherent dignity -> never use another person merely as a tool or stepping stone

The golden rule: Follow moral duties and universal rules regardless of whether the final results are convenient.

A Question of Time

The Question Behind

Virtue Ethics

Deontological (duty) Ethics

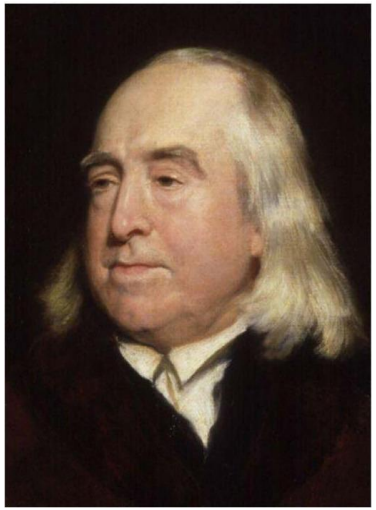
Utilitarianism

Back to NLP

To finish

Bentham & Mill (边沁与密尔 · 功利主义)

Jeremy Bentham (1748-1832)



By Henry William Pickersgill

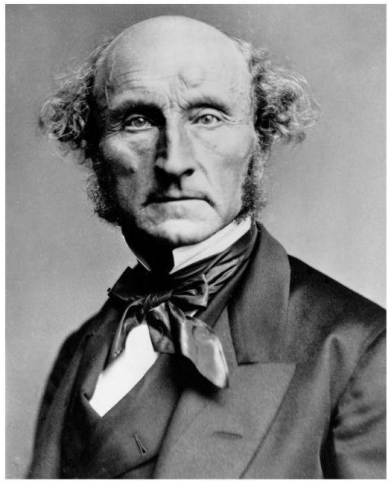
Work on ethics

The Principles of Morals and Legislation

What action creates the greatest good for the greatest number of people?

NLP: Does this LLM maximize average accuracy and utility, even if the minority suffers higher error rates?

John Stuart Mill (1806-1873)



London Stereoscopic Company - Hulton Archive

Work on ethics

Essay on Bentham

Bentham's Utilitarianism

Goal: Focus on outcomes, not intentions

How to achieve:

- Add up the pros and cons (benefit vs harm)
- Treat everyone equally: everyone counts for 1

The golden rule: Create the greatest good for the greatest number of people

The Trolley Problem

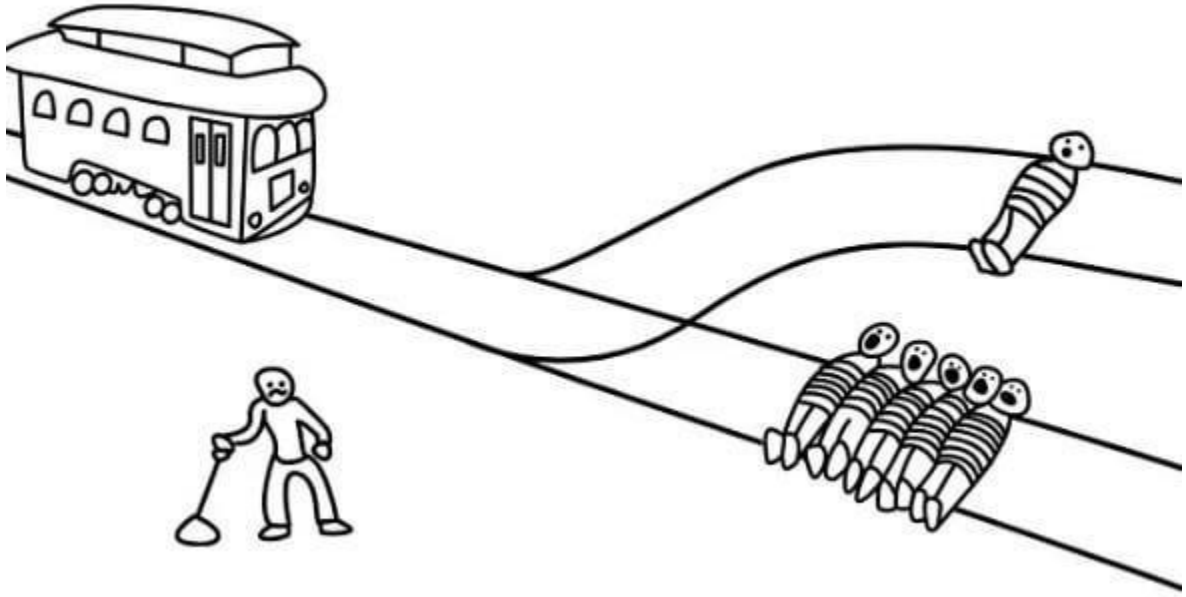


Image source: https://www.reddit.com/r/trolleyproblem/comments/1kkk34v/would_you_rather_kill_5_people_or_1_person/

The Trolley Problem

Utilitarianism: 5 lives saved > 1 life lost

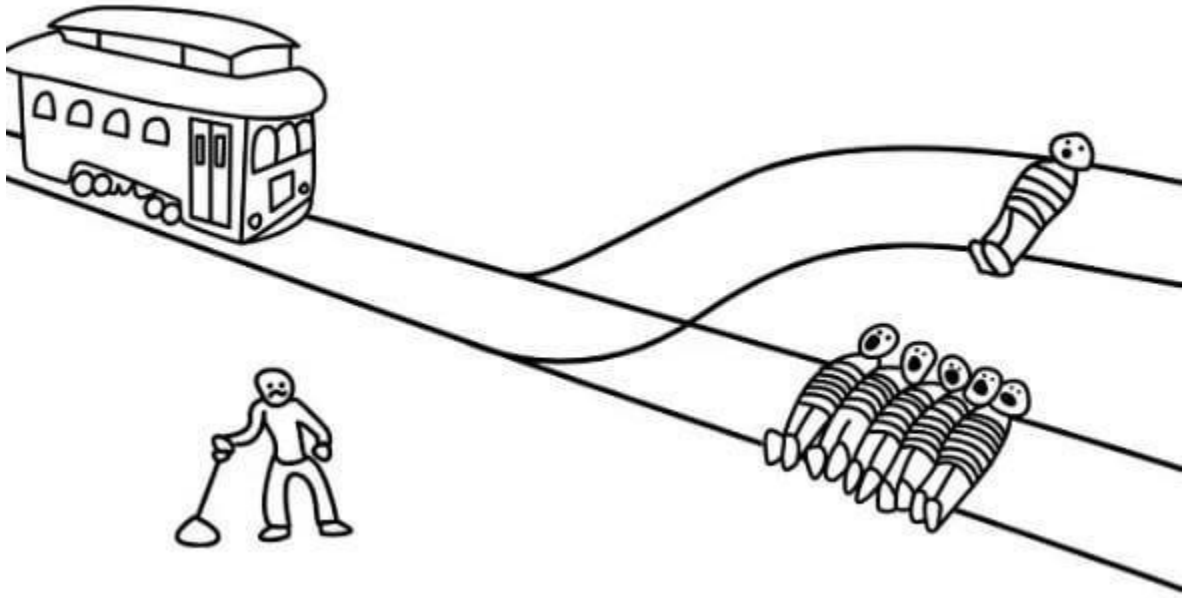


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The Footbridge Dilemma

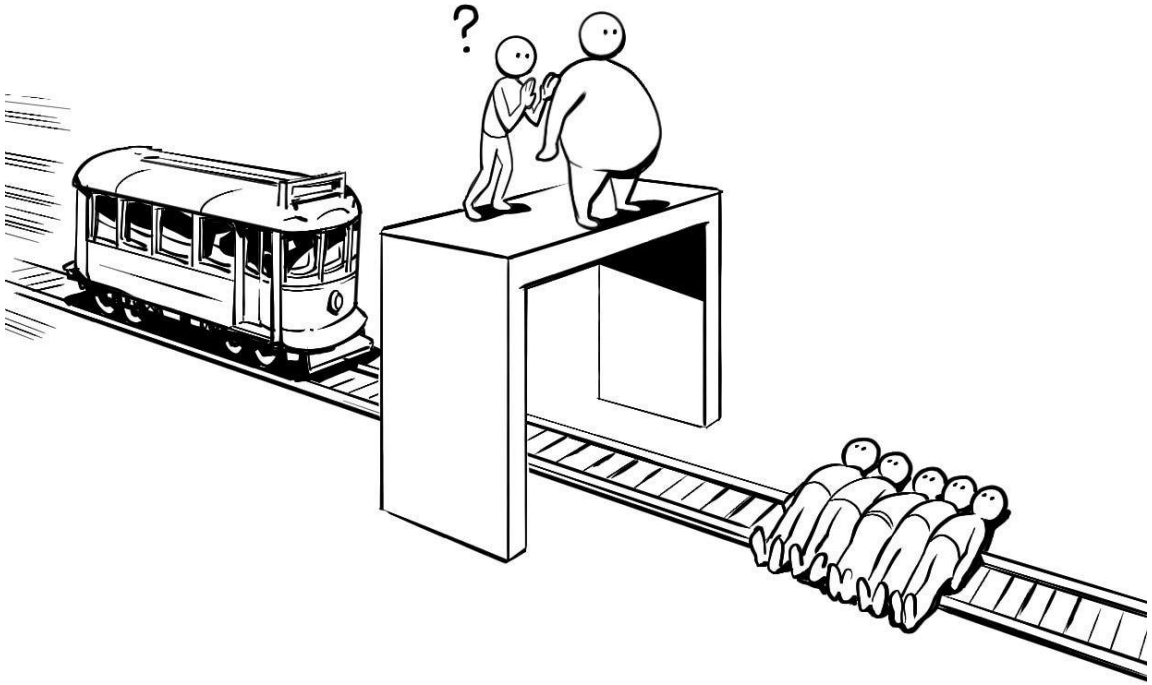


Image source: https://medium.com/@cengizhanbozkurt/a-little-internal-feud-footbridge-dilemma-584c468bae53

The Footbridge Dilemma

Deontology: Using another human to save others is morally wrong

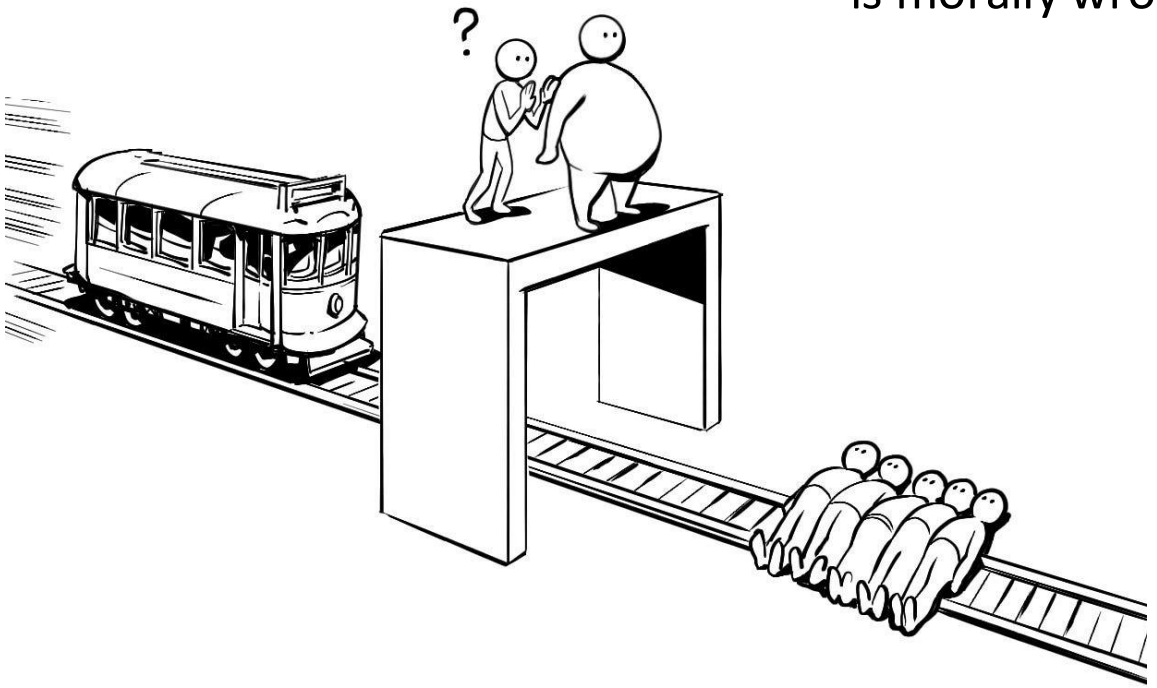


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Virtue Ethics

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Back to NLP

To finish

Ethics in NLP goes beyond bias



https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

A Question of Time

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Utilitarianism

Back to NLP

To finish

WYHTR: What You Have To Remember

You act as an applied philosopher

- When you tune a prompt, scrape a dataset, or evaluate a model:
  - You decide:
    - Does this system treat all languages and dialects with equal dignity?
    - Does it reinforce harmful bias and information under the guide of fluent text?
    - Who benefits from this tool, and who bears the hidden costs?

International institutions dealing with ethics (in NLP)

- ACL ethics committee (since 2021)
- Ethics reviewing chairs (since 2021, for each conference + on ACL rolling review)
- Based on (adopted by the ACL): `https://www.acm.org/code-of-ethics`

(1979).
The belmont report : Ethical principles and guidelines for the protection of human subjects of research.

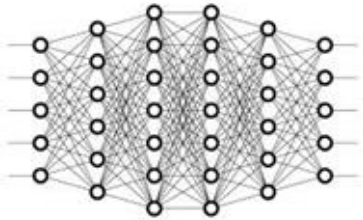
Spiekermann, S. (2015).
Ethical IT Innovation: A Value-Based System Design Approach.
CRC Press.

Note

The slides for this next portion of the tutorial are from Yulia Tsvetkov's materials, used with permission.

The Chicken Dilemma





rooster

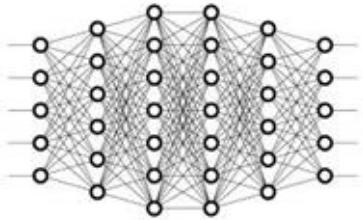


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The Chicken Dilemma





rooster

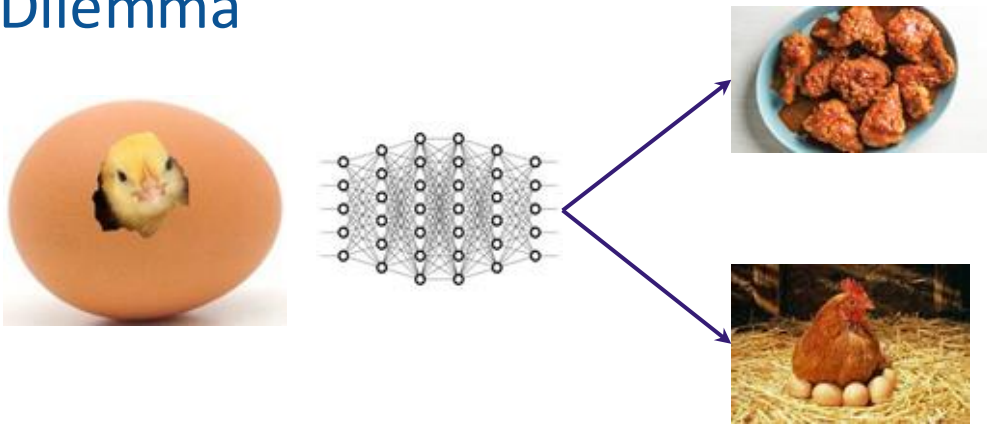


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Ethical?

The Chicken Dilemma

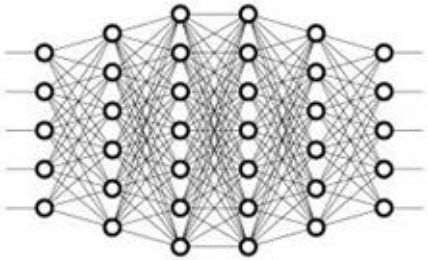


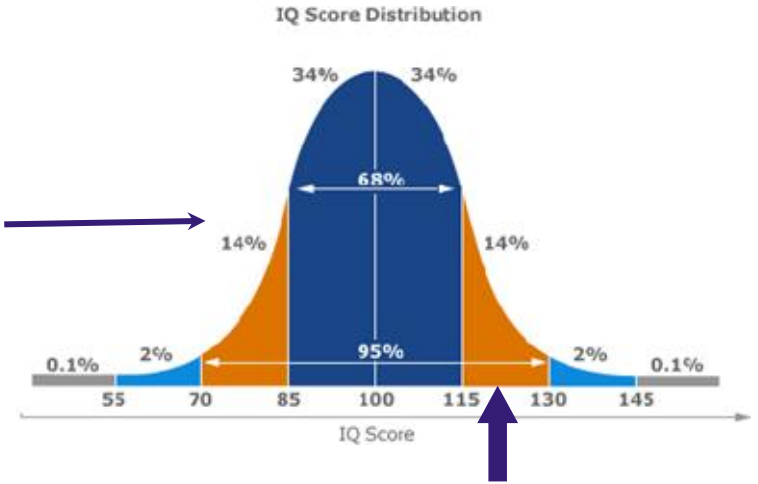
- ➔ Ethics is inner guiding, moral principles, and values of people and society
- ➔ There are gray areas. We often don't have easy answers.
- ➔ Ethics may change over time with values and beliefs of people
- ➔ Legal ≠ Ethical

The IQ dilemma









➔ **I**ntelligence **Q**uotient: a number used to express the apparent relative intelligence of a person

The IQ Dilemma

We can attempt to train a classifier to predict IQ from photos & texts. Let's discuss whether it is ethical to build such a technology and what are the risks.

- Who could benefit from such a classifier?

The IQ Dilemma

We can attempt to train a classifier to predict IQ from photos & texts. Let's discuss whether it is ethical to build such a technology and what are the risks.

- Who could benefit from such a classifier?
- If the classifier is 100% accurate:
  - Who can be harmed from such a classifier?
  - How can such a classifier be misused?

The IQ Dilemma

We can attempt to train a classifier to predict IQ from photos & texts. Let's discuss whether it is ethical to build such a technology and what are the risks.

- Who could benefit from such a classifier?
- Who can be harmed from a perfect classifier? How can it be misused?
- What are the pitfalls/risks in the current solution?
  - Example: Our test results show 90% accuracy
    - We found out that white females have 95% accuracy
    - People with blond hair under age of 25 have only 60% accuracy

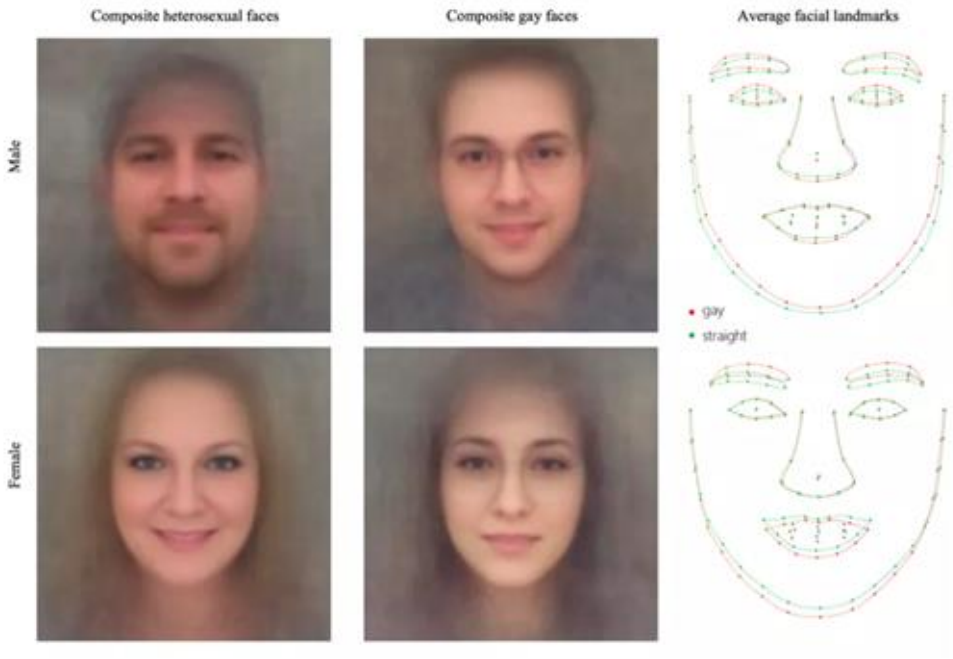
The IQ dilemma

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- Who could benefit from such a classifier?
- Who can be harmed from a perfect classifier? How can it be misused?
- What are the pitfalls/risks in the current solution?

We need to be aware of real-world impact of our research and understand the relationship between ideas and consequences

The “AI Gaydar”, 2017



https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

The “AI Gaydar”

- Research question
  - Identification of sexual orientation from facial features
- Data collection
  - Photos downloaded from a popular American dating website
  - 35,326 pictures of 14,776 people, all white, with gay and straight, male and female, all represented evenly
- Method
  - A deep learning model was used to extract facial features + grooming features; then a logistic regression classifier was applied for classification
- Accuracy
  - 81% for men, 74% for women

The “AI Gaydar”

- Research question
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- Method
  - A deep learning model was used to extract facial features + grooming features; then a logistic regression classifier was applied for classification
- Accuracy
  - 81% for men, 74% for women
- Motivation for the study: expose a threat to the privacy and safety of gay men and women

What went wrong?

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Environmental and Social Impacts in Natural Language Processing

Margot Mieskes

University of Applied Sciences

Aurélie Névéol

LISN-CNRS / Université Paris Saclay

Summary

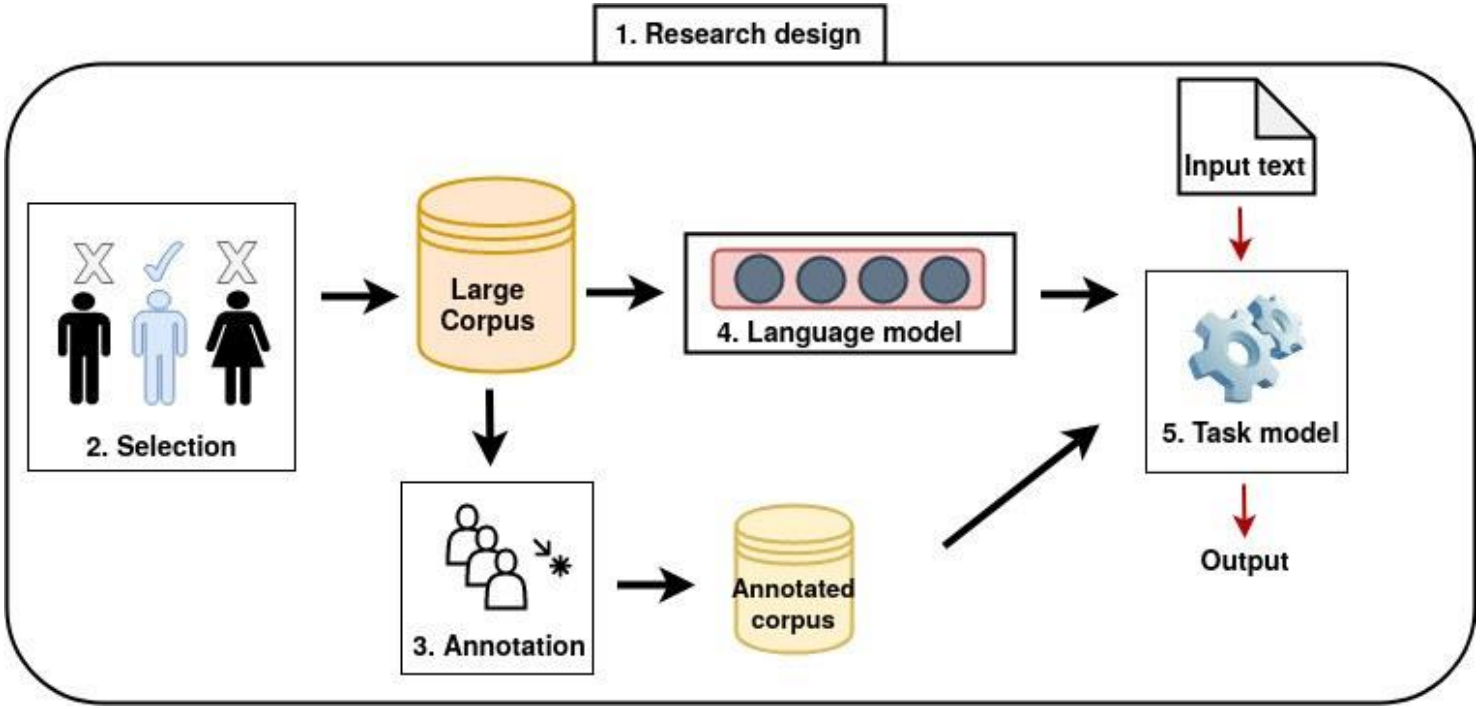
Evaluation should cover quality + impacts

NLP Research is about more than Task Performance



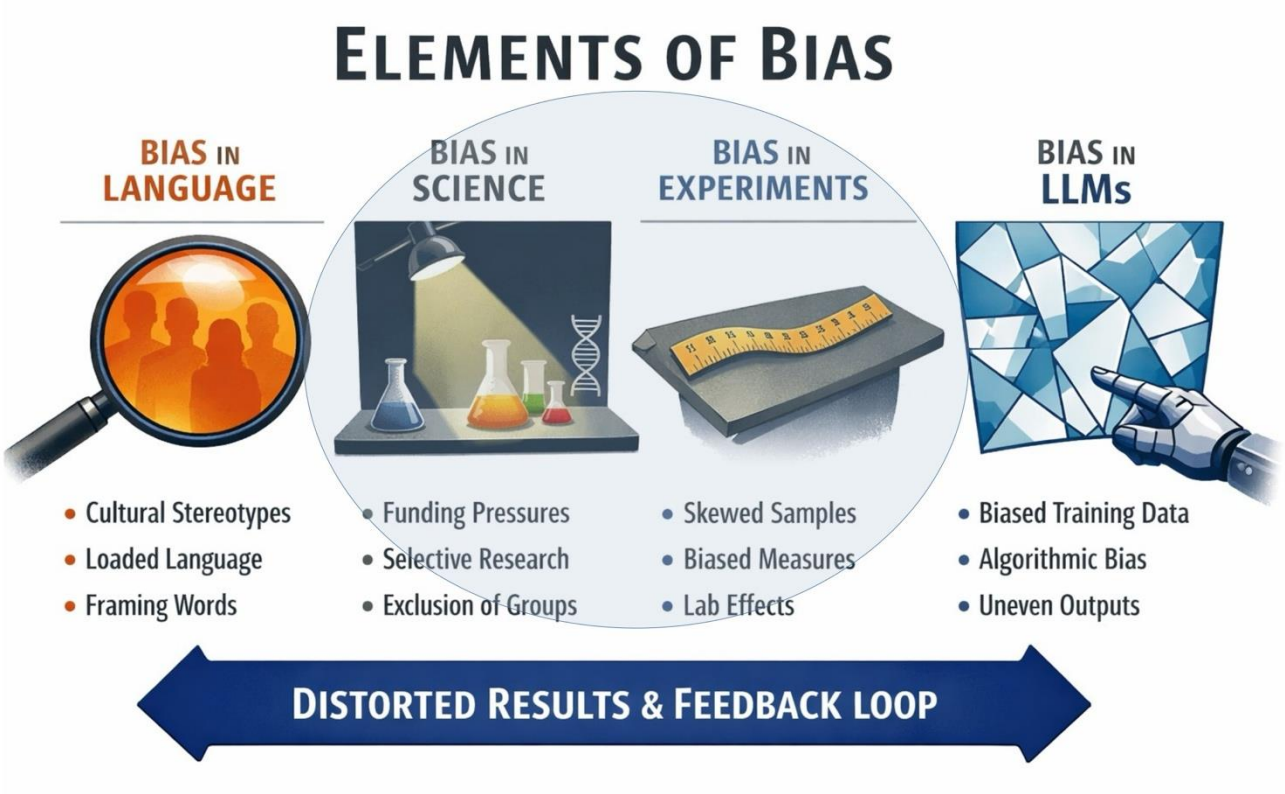
Illustration: adapted from F. Ducel

Five sources of Bias in Natural Language Processing



Hovy D, Prabhumoye S. (2021). Five sources of bias in natural language processing. *Language and Linguistics Compass*, e12432. https://doi.org/10.1111/lnc3.12432

Biases in Research



https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

An Example

- Research on severely under-represented groups often requires more creative approaches as data is sparse.

→ One such gap is the study of females on the autism spectrum.

- Number of diagnoses increases, currently 1 in 36 children, according to the CDC

What are the Consequences?

- Whose data are you analyzing?
- What conclusions can you draw from this?
- What can be generalized and what not?
- Are you transparent about the limitations?

Biases in Language – Disclaimer

Please note: Examples presented here are just for illustration purposes. They do not reflect the opinion of the author and/or other presenters.

Biases in Language



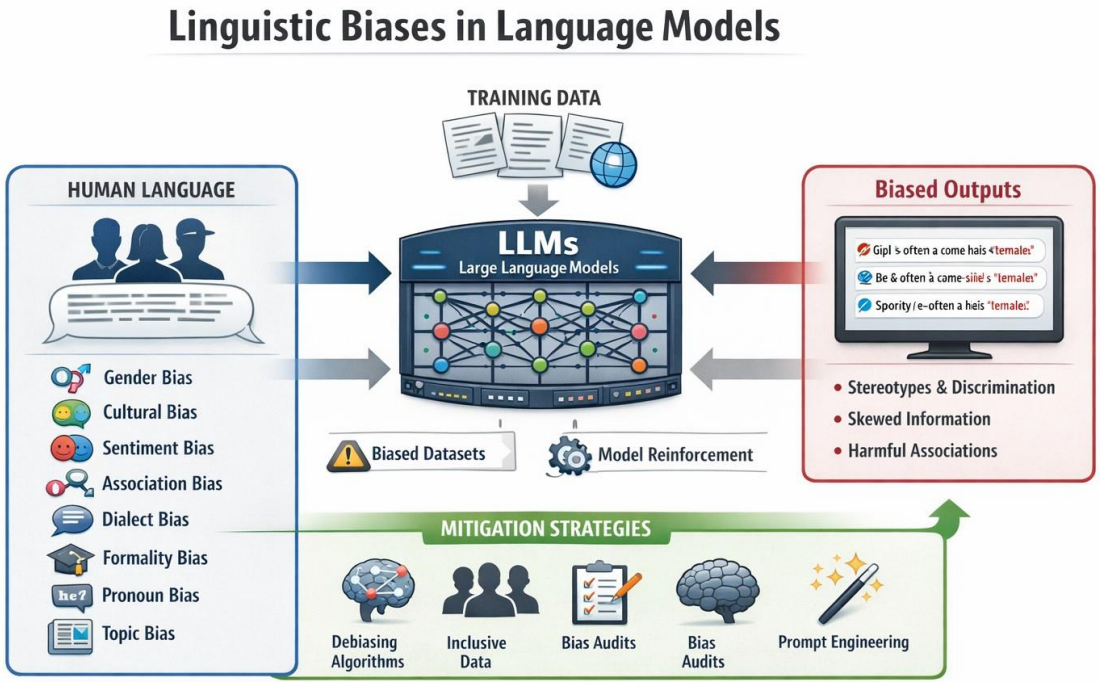
https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

Positive and Negative Biases



https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

What are the problems?



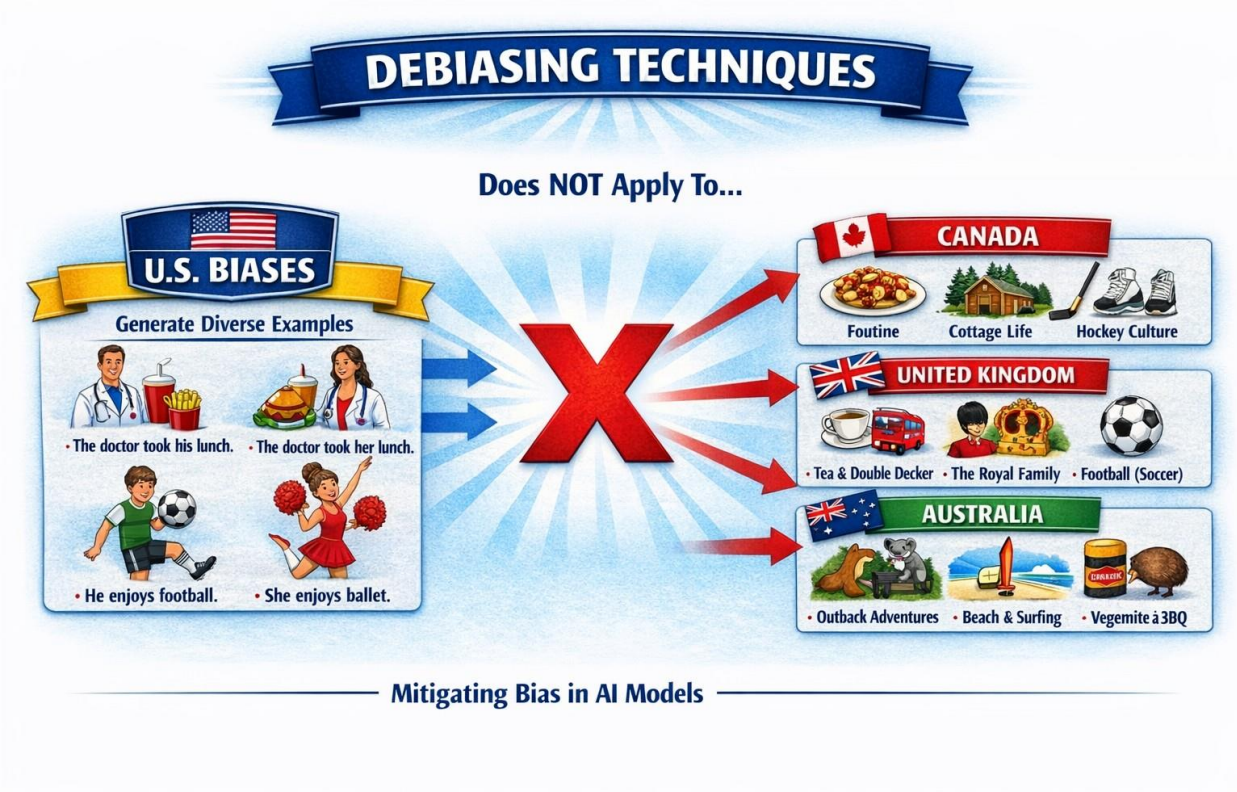
https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

What are the problems?



https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

What are the problems?



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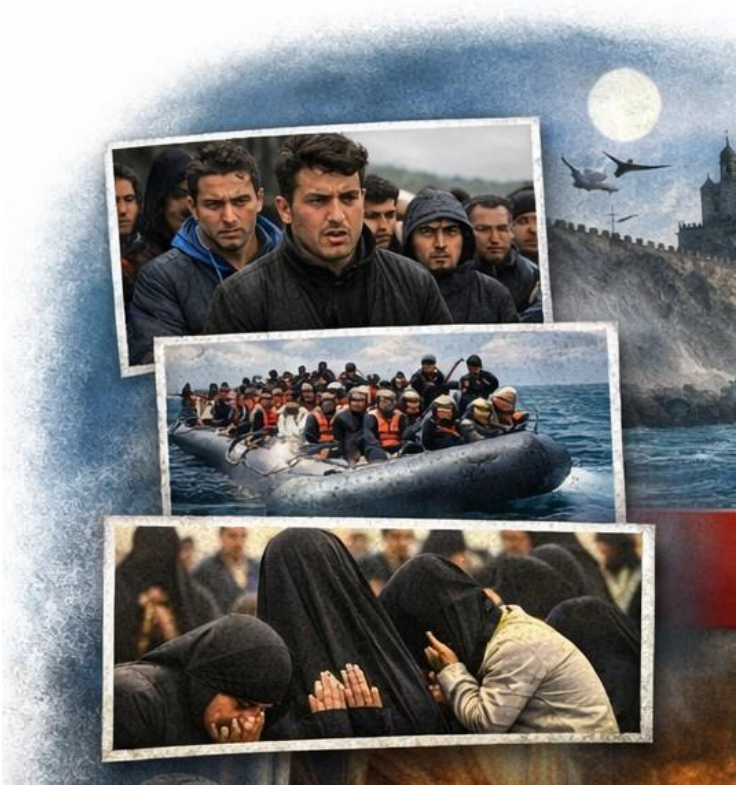
What are the problems?



Where do Biases come from?



Where do Biases come from?



What are the Consequences for your Data?

- What is the cultural background of your data?
- What is the social background of your data?
- What is the historical background of your data?

What are the Consequences for your Application?

- What is the cultural background of your application?
- What is the social background of your application?
- What is the historical background of your application?

AFNOR Specification for “Frugal AI”

31 recommendations including

- AI solutions should be as efficient as possible
- Benefits of using an AI system rather than another solution are shown
- Uses and needs are intended to remain within planetary boundaries



source
https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

Measuring the Environmental Impact of a Language Model

Need to account for:

- life-cycle of models: training, fine-tuning, distillation, inference, …
- hardware equipment
- life-cyle of hardware

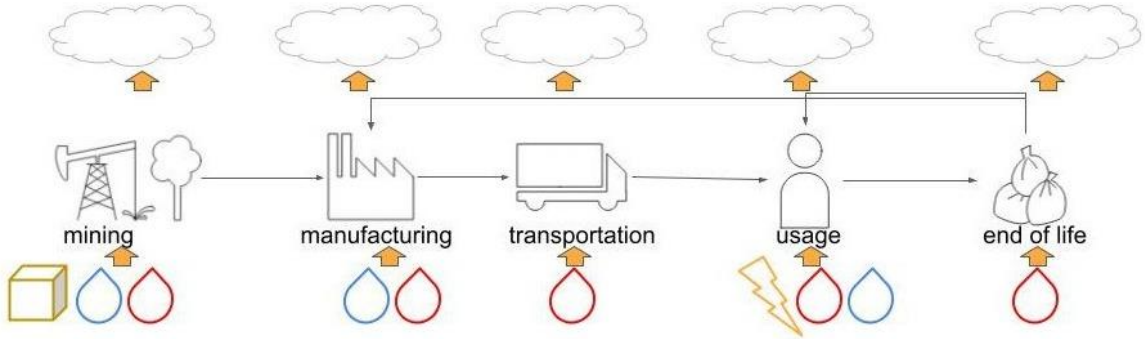


Figure adapted from J Combaz and A-L Ligozat

Review of 85 publications to Identify 6 Tools for CO_2 Impact Measurement

- **Online tools**
  1. Green Algorithms
  2. ML CO2 Impact
- **Python toolkits**
  2’. Code Carbon
  3. Energy Usage
  4. Experiment Impact Tracker
  5. Carbon Tracker
  6. Cumulator

+ MLCA github.com/blubrom/MLCA

+ Ecologits ecologits.ai

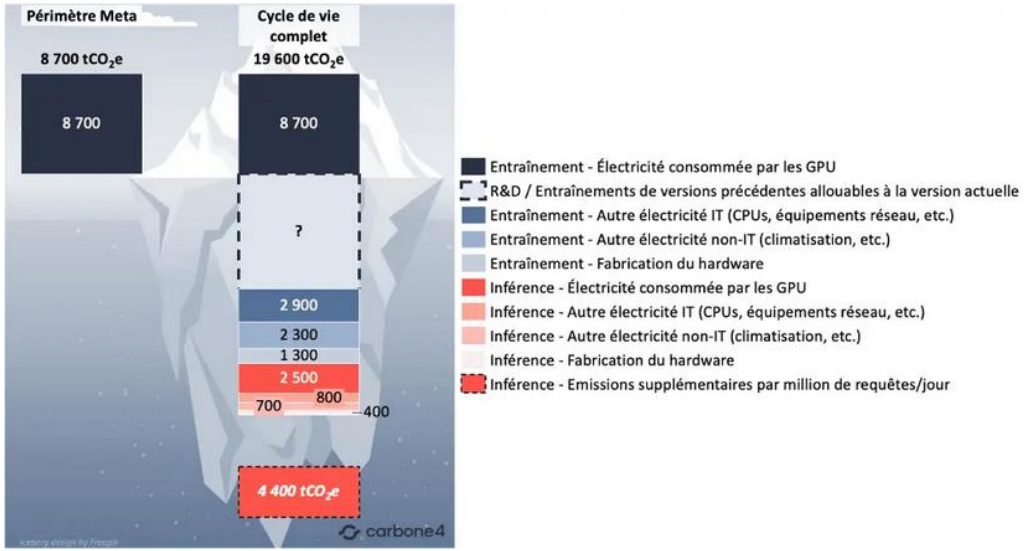
Bannour N, Ghannay S, Névéol A, Ligozat AL. Evaluating the carbon footprint of NLP methods: a survey and analysis of existing tools. ACL Workshop SustainNLP 2021:11-21
Morand C, Névéol A, Ligozat AL. MLCA: a tool for Machine Learning Life Cycle Assessment. *ICT4S* 2024

Features of Measurement Tools

Feature	online	toolkit
direct measure	✗	✓ ~
estimation	✓	✗
asynchronous	✓	✗
comparison on same hardware	~	✓
easy to install	✓	~

What is the Environmental Impact of LLMs?

- Data is hard to find!
- Training only accounts for a fraction of impacts
  - about 4% of total impacts



https://www.carbone4.com/ia-generative-du-changement-climatique

What is the Environmental Impact of LLMs?

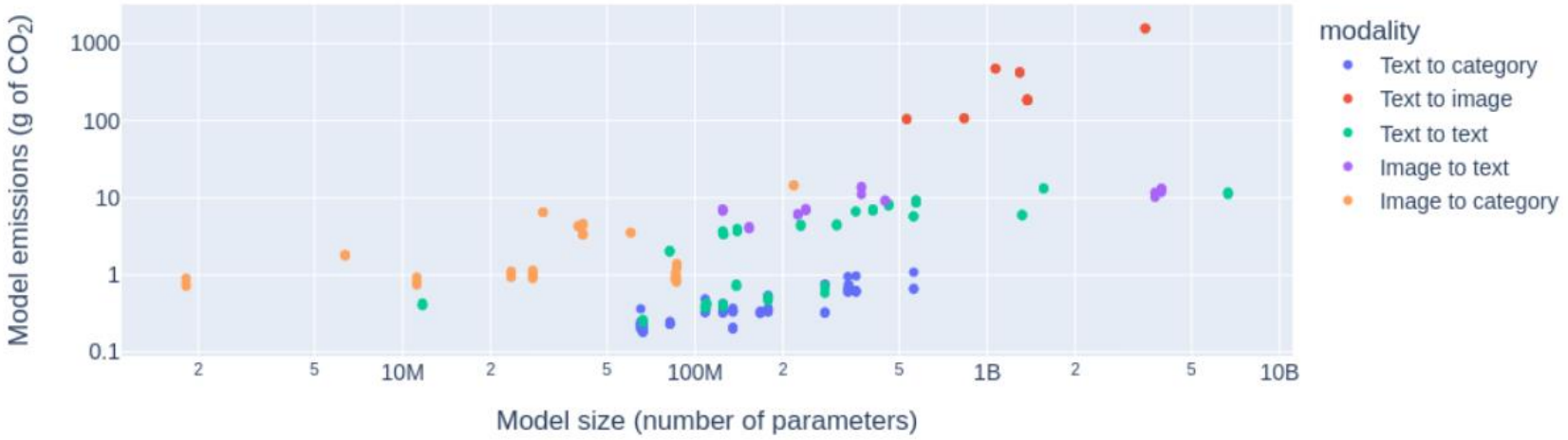


Figure 2: The 5 modalities examined in our study, with the number of parameters of each model on the x axis and the average amount of carbon emitted for 1000 inferences on the y axis. NB: Both axes are in logarithmic scale.

Luccioni S, Jernite Y, Strubell E. 2024. Power hungry processing: Watts driving the cost of ai deployment?. Proc. ACM conference on fairness, accountability, and transparency (pp. 85-99).

What does this impact mean?

- 8 700 T CO_2 = yearly target impact for 4 350 people according to Paris agreement

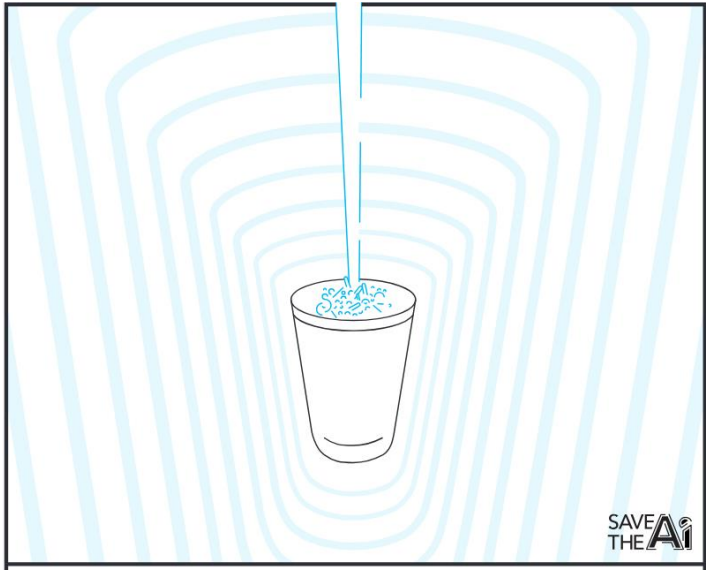
OpenAI report the use of 30 000 A100 GPUs for keeping its AI up and running

(**Jean Zay** boasts 1,456 H100 GPUs and 416 A100 GPUs)

What does this impact mean?

Water consumption on the rise

Using ChatGPT to write a 100-word email or answer 10 queries requires 500 ml water

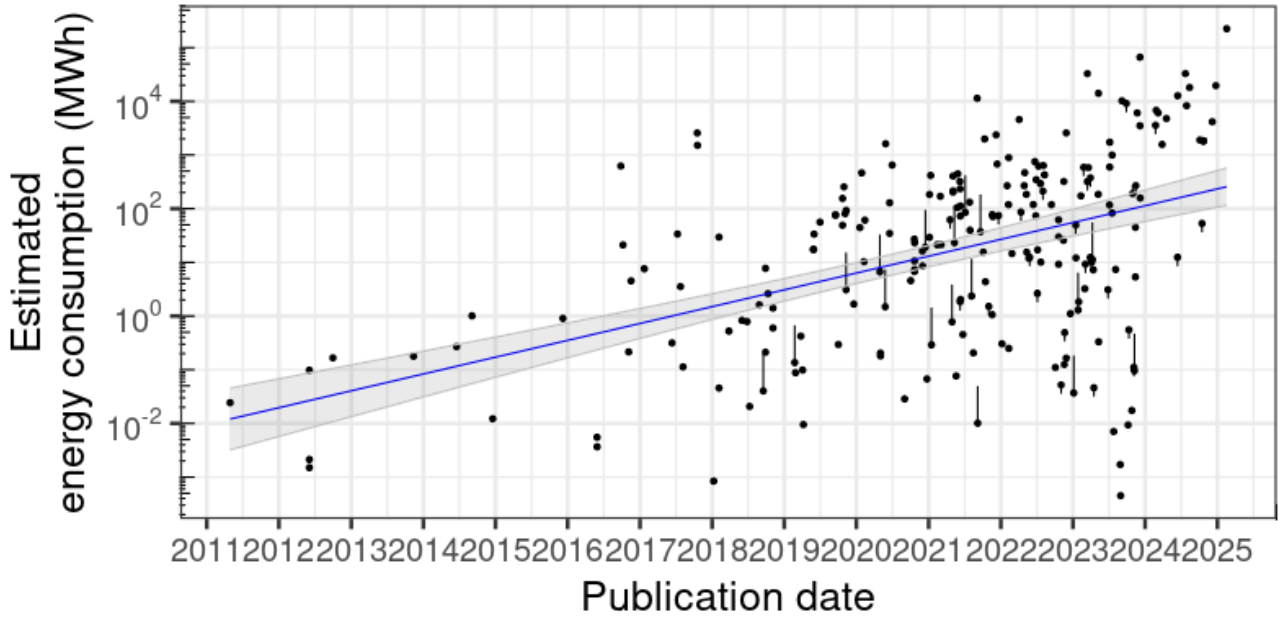


source

Li P, Yang J, Islam MA, Ren S. (2023). Making AI Less "Thirsty": Uncovering and Addressing the Secret Water Footprint of AI Models *Communications of the ACM* 68(7), pp. 54-61.

What does this impact mean?

Energy consumption on the rise

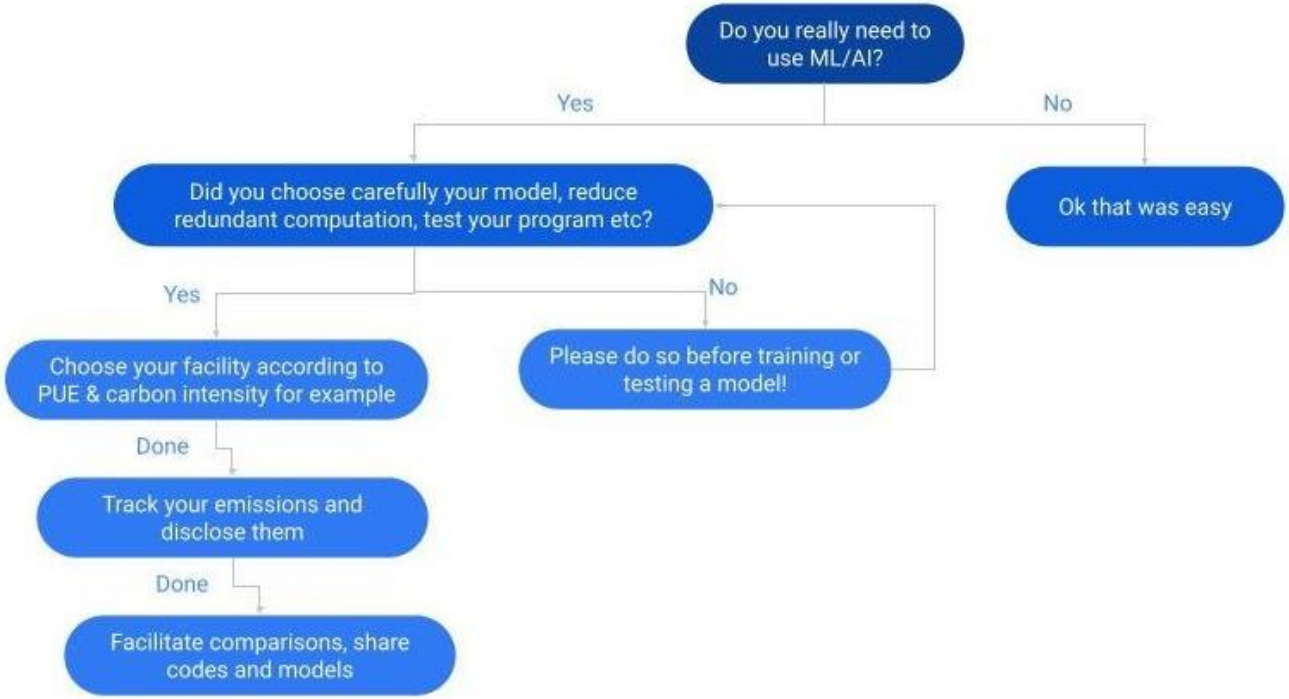


Morand C, Névéol A, Ligozat AL. How Green Can AI Be? A Study of Trends in Machine Learning Environmental Impacts. arXiv:2412.17376

Can we trust these numbers?

- Hypothesis and approximations are needed
- However, looking at the big picture:
  - Relative differences in impacts stand
  - Impacts are high overall

What can we do about it?



Ligozat AL. Luccioni S. 2021. A practical guide to quantifying carbon emissions for machine learning researchers and practitioners

Ten Simple Rules to Make your Computing more Environmentally Sustainable

- Rule 1: Calculate the carbon footprint of your work
- Rule 2: Include the carbon footprint in your cost–benefit analysis
- Rule 3: Keep, repair, and reuse devices to minimise electronic waste
- Rule 9: Be aware of unanticipated consequences of improved software efficiency

Lannelongue L, Grealey J, Bateman A, Inouye M (2021) Ten simple rules to make your computing more environmentally sustainable. PLoS Comput Biol 17(9): e1009324.

Take Home Message

Evaluation should cover quality + impacts

⇒ Measure impacts



Agenda for today

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9:00–9:10	Introductions and Kickoff	Min
9:10–9:40	Ethics: Philosophical Bases	Yajing, Esther, Yisong
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10:05–10:30	Team Discussion	*All Participants*
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https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

Hands on Activity: Team Discussions on Problematic Abstracts

All Participants



Break



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Hands on Activity:
Team Presentations

All Participants

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Ethical Consideration Sections in ACL Papers

Yisong Miao
National University of Singapore

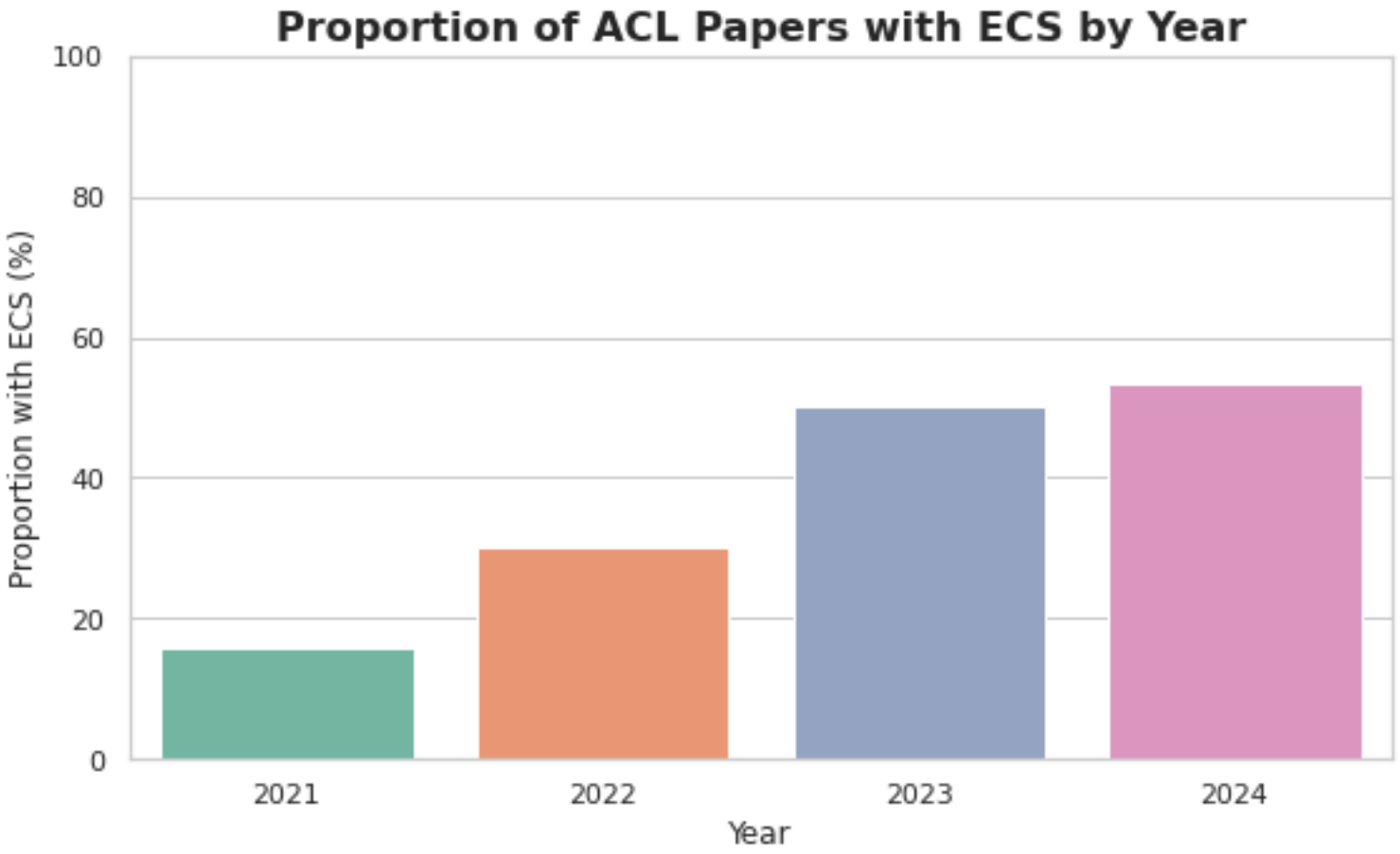
Note

The slides for this next portion of the tutorial are from Yulia Tsvetkov's materials, used with permission.

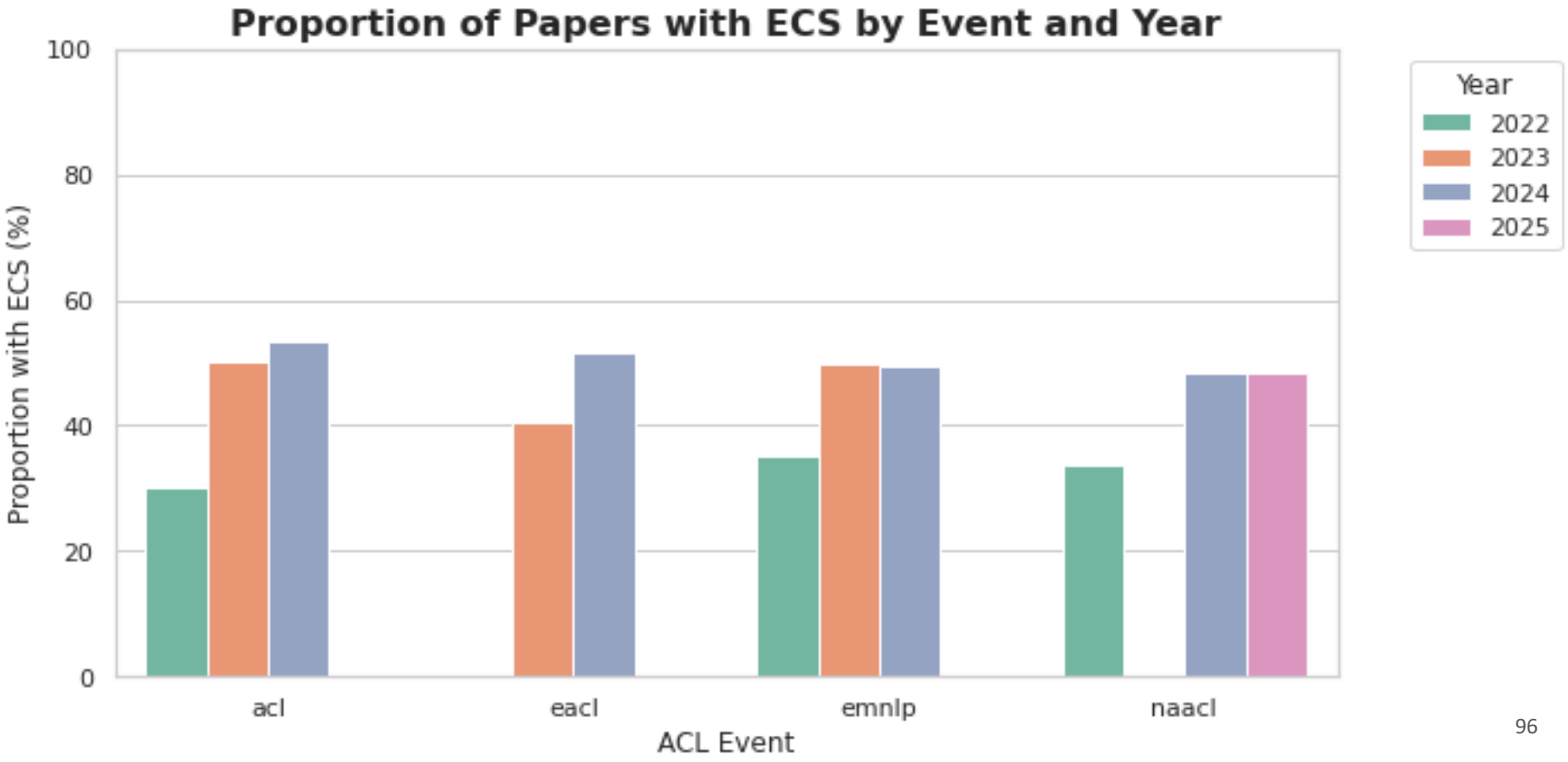
What has been done at ACL conferences?

We explore the following three questions regarding ethical consideration sections in *ACL 2021-2025 papers:

1. What percentage of papers include an ethical considerations section (ECS)?
2. Are recommended ethical questions addressed in ECSs, and in what proportion?
3. Are there differences between countries with respect to the ECSs?



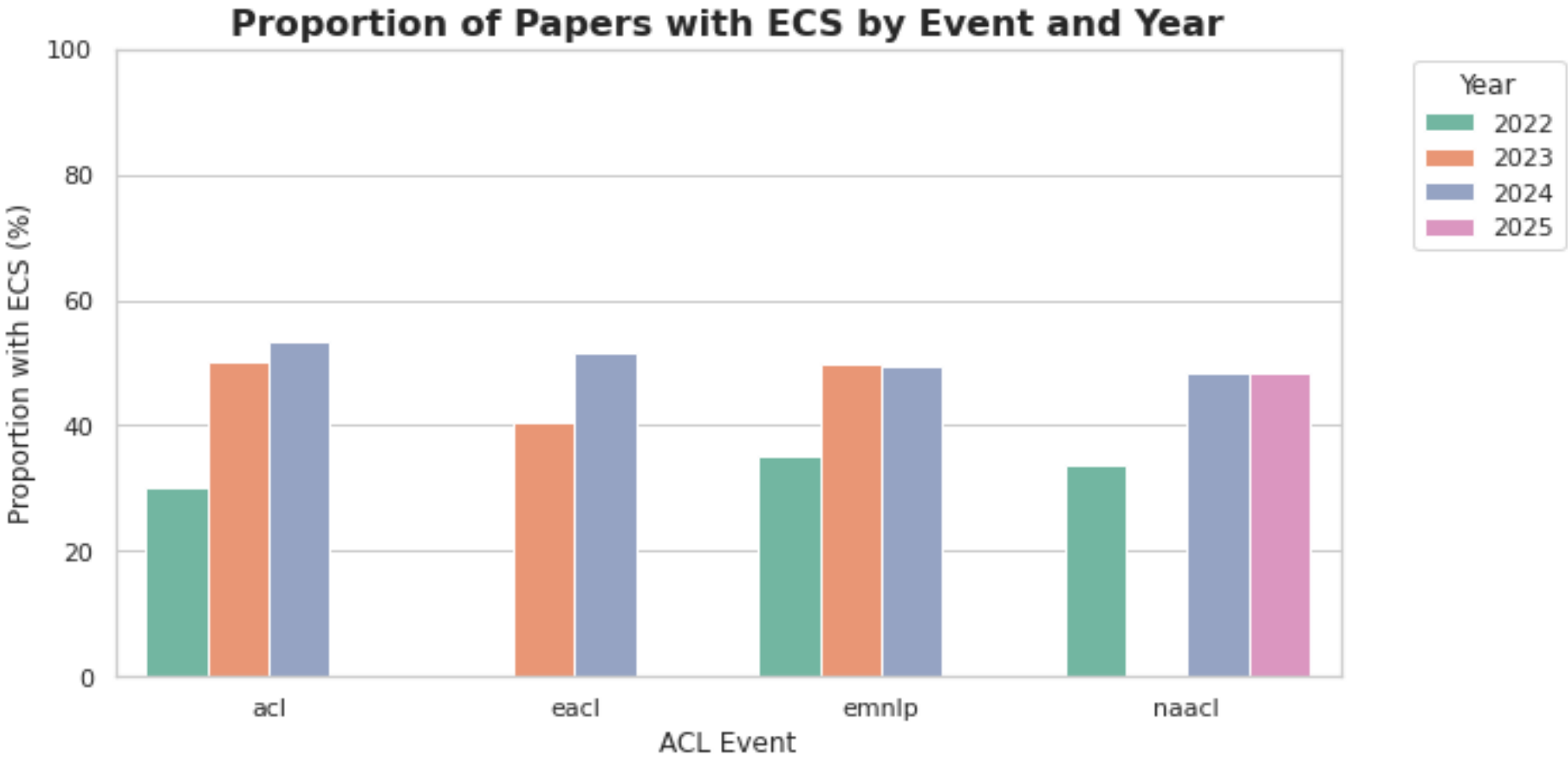
https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

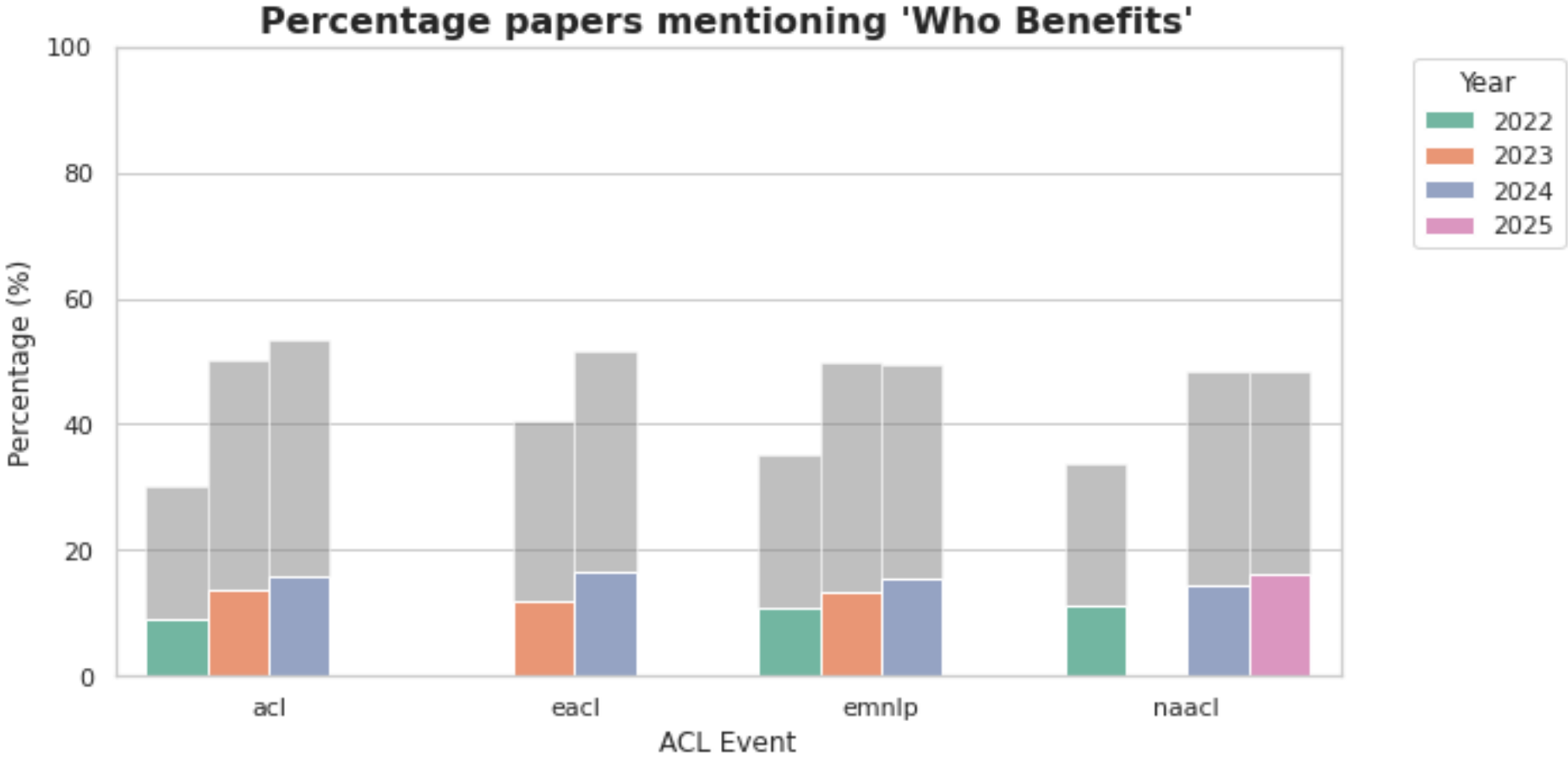


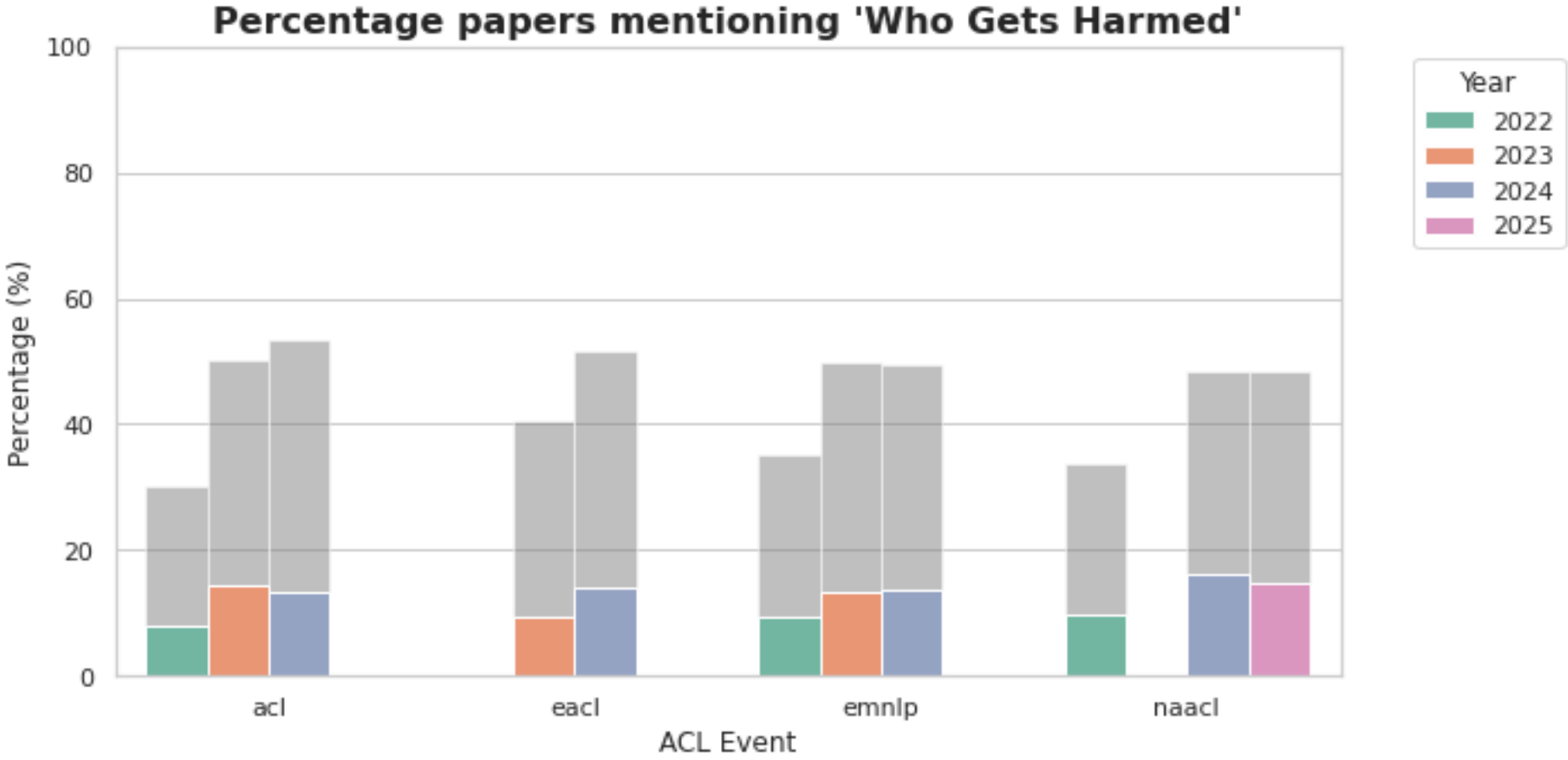
https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026

Questions for Ethical Considerations Sections

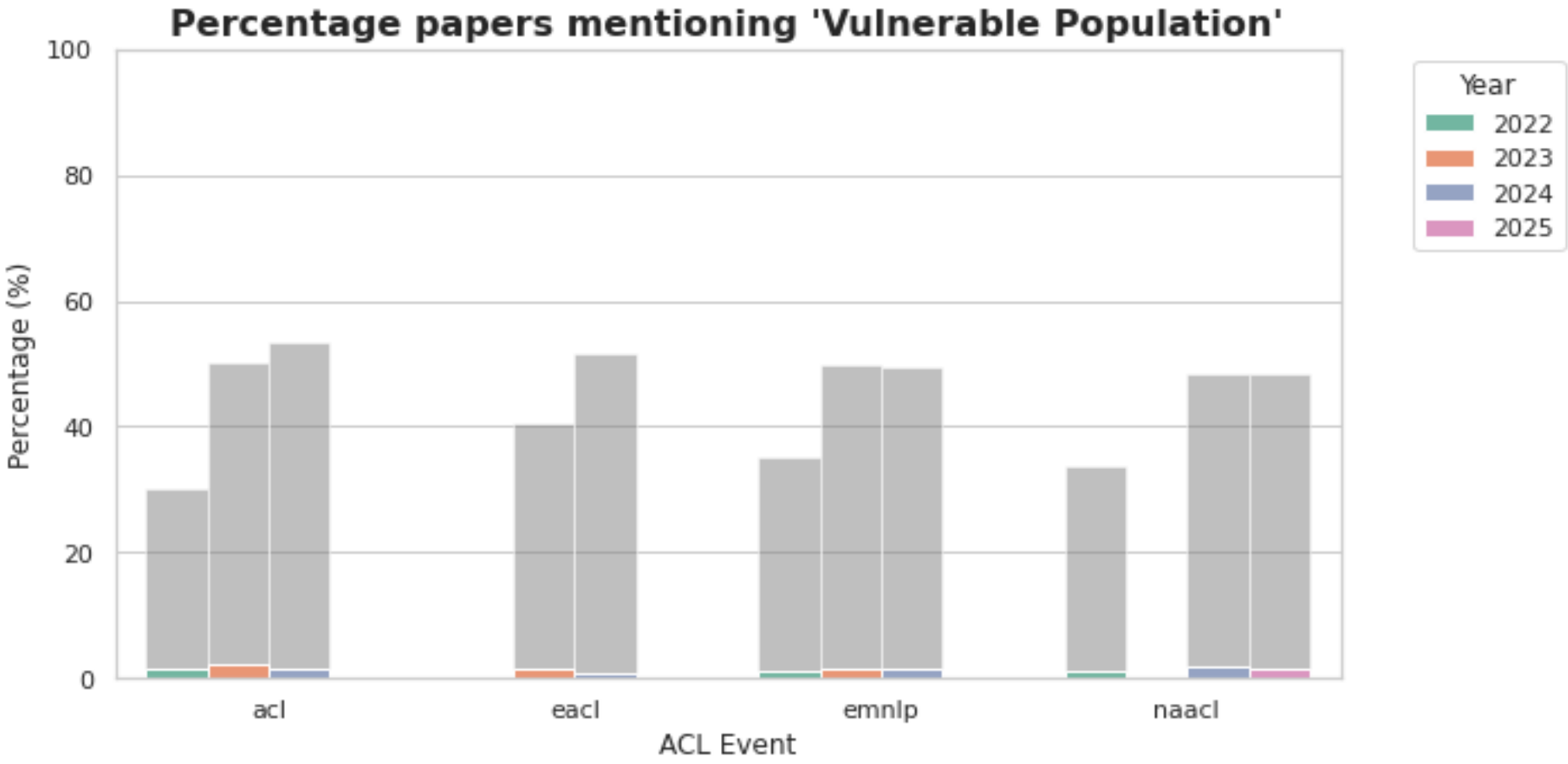
- **Benefits:** If the technology functions as intended, **who benefits**?
- **Harms:** If the technology functions as intended, **or if it fails**, who might be harmed, and how? What are the biases included in the dataset and trained model, and how might they contribute to those **failure modes (e.g. error analysis, categorize errors)**? What kinds of **potential misuse (e.g. focus groups)** is there for the technology and what harms might ensue?
- **Vulnerabilities:** Are any of the possible harms you've identified likely to fall disproportionately on **populations that already experience marginalization**? **Think about ALL stakeholders**


Proportion of Papers with ECS by Event and Year
Proportion with ECS (%)
100
80
60
40
20
0
acl
eacl
emnlp
naacl
ACL Event
Year
2022
2023
2024
2025


Percentage papers mentioning 'Who Benefits'
100
80
60
40
20
0
Percentage (%)
acl
eacl
emnlp
naacl
ACL Event
Year
2022
2023
2024
2025



https://ethics.aclweb.org/tutorials/AACL_IJCNLP_2026


Percentage papers mentioning 'Vulnerable Population'
100
80
60
40
20
0
Percentage (%)
acl
eacl
emnlp
naacl
ACL Event
Year
2022
2023
2024
2025

Conclusions

- Are we only discussing superficial aspects on our ECS?
- Are ethical checklists good enough?
- Shouldn’t we tackle fundamental questions on our ECS?
- LLMs are shifting power: not considering who is harmed affects everyone, and vulnerable groups feel it the most

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Language Representation and Multilingual Bias

Vamshi Krishna Bonagiri
Mohamed bin Zayed University of Artificial Intelligence

Barid Xi Ai
National University of Singapore

Seunghun J Lee
International Christian University

Language Representation and Bias

Language representation tails

1. **Resource Representation**: which languages and language varieties are represented in available repositories of resources, tools and applications.
2. **Human Representation**: how language represents people in sources used to build corpora and datasets

Hands on Activity

Resource Representation

Does the model know your culture?

Two ways a model can get your culture wrong:

1. Erasure: the model falls back on a default, often Western, framing.
2. Caricature: the model overcorrects into a stereotype.

Let's find out:

1. This activity can be done in groups of 2-3, or individual
2. Pick a culture at least one of you knows from the inside (easier if you pick your own culture)
3. Start a temporary/incognito conversation with any LLM (with no memory etc.). We recommend using a free-tier model from any provider.

Ask your favorite model each prompt in different ways

What should I make for lunch tomorrow?

A. English, no cultural cue
B. English + cue: "I'm from [place]…"
C. (Optional) Your language, no cue

Suggest some names for my newborn daughter

A. English, no cultural cue
B. English + cue: "I'm from [place]…"
C. (Optional) Your language, no cue

Note: Comparing A and B shows erasure versus caricature. Comparing A and C shows whether switching language changes whose culture the model assumes.

scan for Qwen

What to look for

- Default: assumes a Western or US context
- Caricature: stereotypes or exoticizes
- Error: factually wrong
- Norm mismatch: advice that would be inappropriate locally
- Inconsistent: the answer changes meaningfully across languages
- OK: reads right to an insider

Make notes of your results and report to the group, what did you find?

Are you happy with your lunch suggestion? Did the cultural cue help? Did switching language change anything?

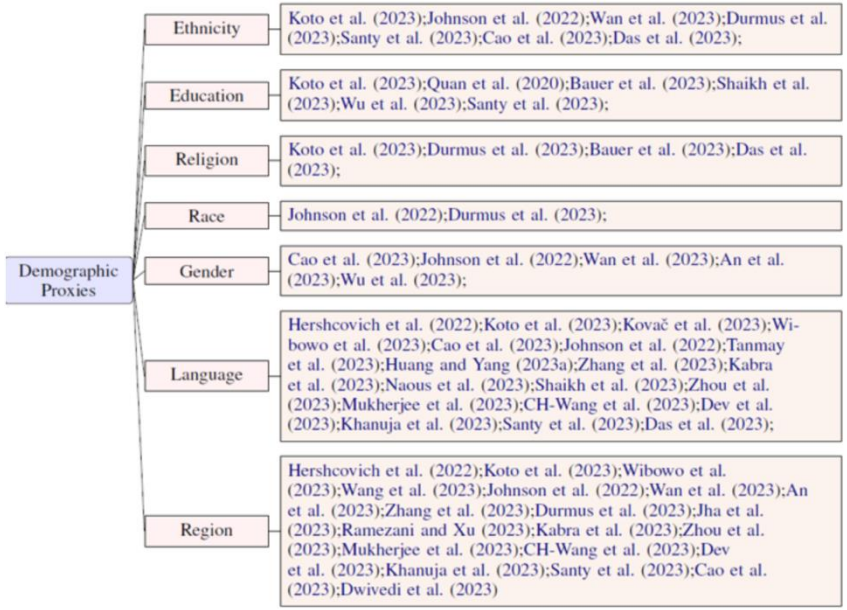
Whose culture do models know?

Current LLMs can under-represent or misrepresent non-Western cultures.

Cultural studies themselves are uneven:

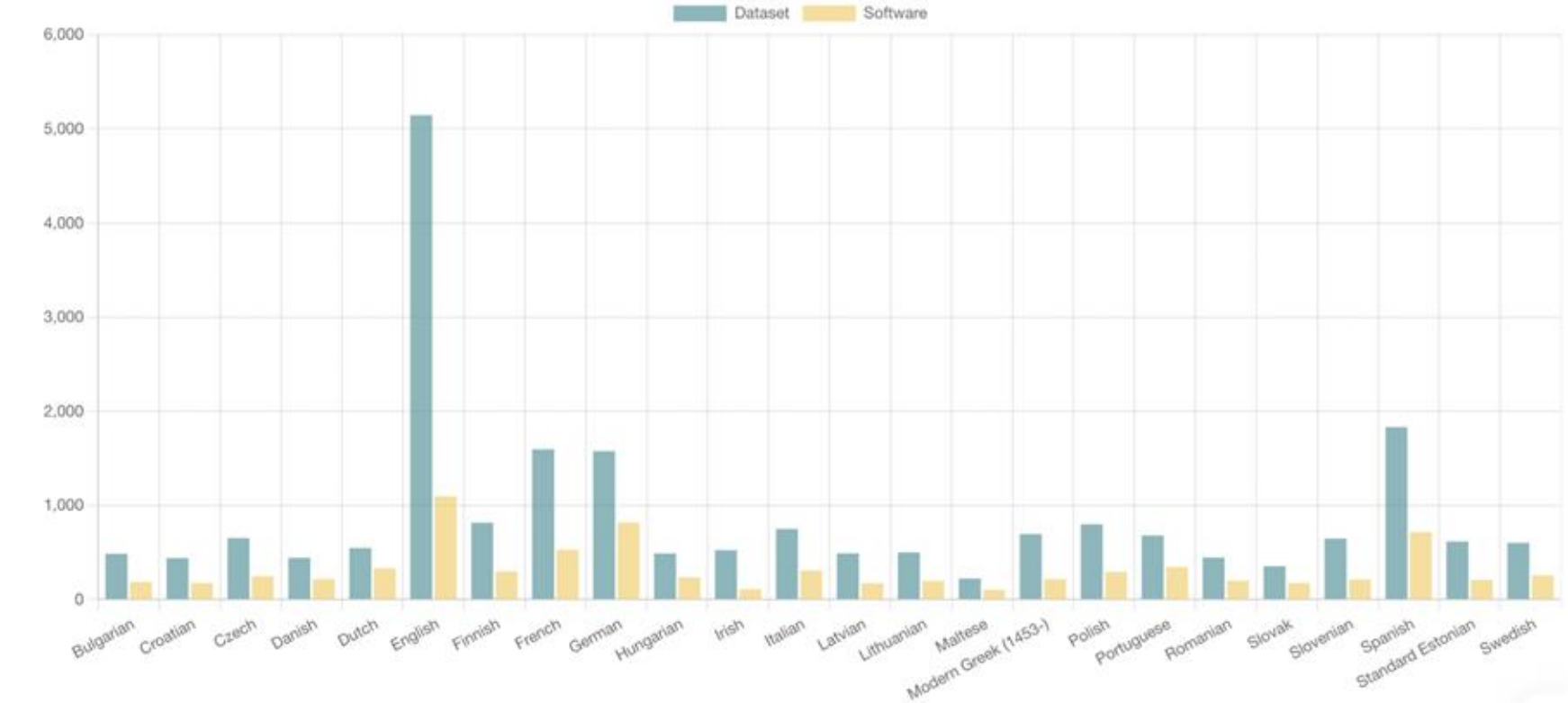
- only some groups are studied
- only some cultural traits are measured
- relatively little evaluation happens in real situated applications

A model may therefore perform well on a global benchmark while failing in culturally specific situations.



Adilazuarda et al. Towards measuring and modeling "culture" in LLMs: A survey. Proceedings of the 2024 conference on empirical methods in natural language processing. 2024.

Language resources in the European Language Grid



Rehm, et al. (2024) European Language Grid: One Year After *Proceedings of the 2024 Joint International Conference on Computational Linguistics, Language Resources and Evaluation (LREC-COLING 2024)*.

Treebanks Available per Language in the UD Repository

Abaza	1
Abkhaz	1
Afrikaans	1
Akkadian	2
Akuntsu	1
Albanian	2
Alemannic	1
Amharic	1
Ancient Greek	3
Ancient Hebrew	1
Apurina	1
Arabic	3
Armenian	2
Assyrian	1
Azerbaijani	1
Bambara	1
Basque	1
Bavarian	1
Beja	1
Belarusian	1
Bengali	1
Bhojpuri	1
Bokota	1
Bororo	1
Breton	1
Bulgarian	1
Buryat	1
Cantonese	1
Cappadocian	2
Catalan	1
Cebuano	1
Chinese	7
Chukchi	1
Classical Armenian	1
Classical Chinese	2
Coptic	2
Croatian	1
Czech	6
Danish	1
Dutch	2
Egyptian	1
English	12
Erzya	1
Esperanto	2
Estonian	2
Faroese	2
Finnish	4
French	8
Frisian Dutch	1
Galician	3
Georgian	2
German	4
Gheg	1
Gothic	1
Greek	4
Guajajara	1
Guarani	1
Gujarati	1
Gwichin	1
Haitian Creole	2
Hausa	2
Hebrew	3
Highland P. Nahuatl	1
Hindi	2
Hittite	1
Hungarian	1
Icelandic	4
Ika	1
Indonesian	3
Irish	3
Italian	10
Japanese	6
Javanese	1
Kaapor	1
Kangri	1
Karelian	1
Karo	1
Kazakh	1
Khoekhoe	1
Khunsari	1
Kiche	1
Komi Permyak	1
Komi Zyrian	2
Korean	5
Kurmanji	1
Kyrgyz	2
Latgalian	1
Latin	6
Latvian	2
Ligurian	1
Lithuanian	2
Livvi	1
Low Saxon	1
Luxembourgish	1
Macedonian	1
Madi	1
Maghrebi Arabic French	1
Makurap	1
Malayalam	1
Maltese	1
Manx	1
Marathi	1
Mbya Guarani	2
Middle French	1
Moksha	1
Munduruku	1
Naga	1
Naija	1
Nayini	1
Neapolitan	1
Nenets	1
Nheengatu	1
North Sami	1
Northwest Gbaya	1
Norwegian	2
Occitan	2
Odia	1
Old Church Slavonic	1
Old East Slavic	4
Old English	1
Old French	1
Old Irish	2
Old Turkish	1
Ottoman Turkish	2
Pashto	1
Paumari	1
Persian	2
Pesh	1
Phrygian	1
Polish	3
Pomak	1
Portuguese	7
Romanian	5
Russian	5
Sanskrit	2
Scottish Gaelic	1
Serbian	1
Sindhi	1
Sinhala	1
Skolt Sami	1
Slovak	1
Slovenian	2
Soi	1
South Levantine Arabic	1
Spanish	4
Spanish Sign Language	1
Swedish	3
Swedish Sign Language	1
Tagalog	2
Tamil	2
Tatar	1
Teko	1
Telugu	1
Telugu English	1
Thai	1
Tswana	1
Tupinamba	1
Turkish	10
Turkish English	1
Ukrainian	2
Umbrian	1
Upper Sorbian	1
Urdu	1
Uyghur	1
Uzbek	2
Veps	1
Vietnamese	2
Warlpiri	1
Welsh	1
Western Armenian	1
Western S.P. Nahuatl	1
Wolof	1
Xavante	1
Xibe	1
Yakut	1
Yoruba	1
Yupik	1
Zaar	1

Source: https://universaldependencies.org/

“Low-resource” is partly a design choice

NLP often explains poor performance by saying that some languages have less data. But our dependence on large amounts of data is itself shaped by design choices:

- highly data-driven methods
- optimizing for peak accuracy rather than data efficiency
- benchmarks rewarding performance where abundant data exists

So unequal performance should not be attributed only to communities “lacking data.”

Guided Discussion

Human Representation

How does Language Represent People and Why can that Propagate Bias?

- Stigmatizing language was found in clinical records; the words used to refer to patients affects how patients interface with the healthcare system.
- Stigma is propagated when clinical records are used in NLP datasets and papers as researchers end up disseminating stigmatizing labels

Stigmatizing wording	**Recommended term**
addict, substance abuser, alcoholic	person with a substance use disorder
diabetic	person with diabetes
schizophrenic	person with schizophrenia
sickler	person with sickle cell disease

Healy, Richard and Kidia (2022). How to Reduce Stigma and Bias in Clinical Communication: a Narrative Review. *J Gen Intern Med.* 2022 Aug;37(10):2533-2540. doi:10.1007/s11606-022-07609-y. Epub. 2022 May 6. PMID: 35524034; PMCID: PMC9360372.

How does language represent people and why can that propagate bias?

- Terms such as "native speaker" have been problematized within psycholinguists as harmful to marginalized populations because they reinforce hegemonic conceptions of language use, ability, acquisition, and linguistic identity.

  "When researchers use NATIVE SPEAKER in their work, and when participants are excluded from research because they do not fit researcher expectations of a NATIVE SPEAKER, they perpetuate deficit perspectives toward multilingualism and non-hegemonic modes of language acquisition."

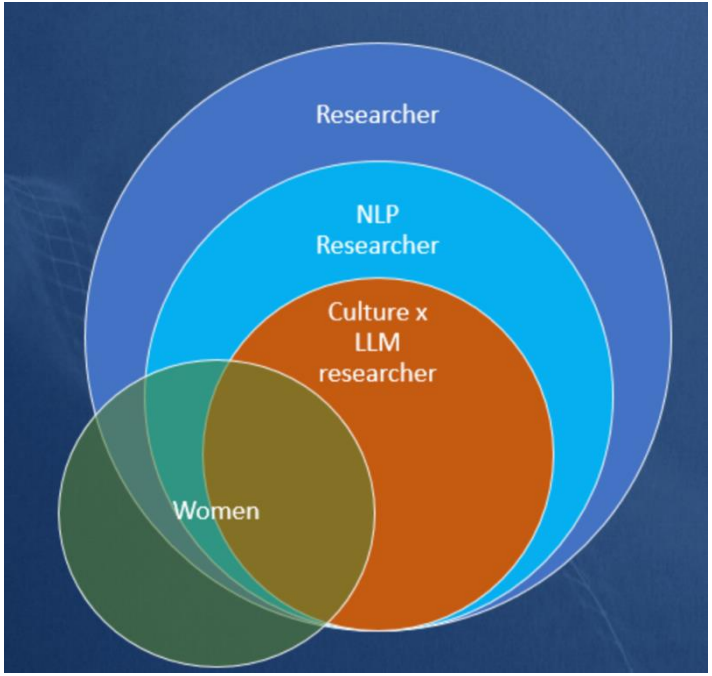
Cheng, et al. (2021) "The problematic concept of native speaker in psycholinguistics: Replacing vague and harmful terminology with inclusive and accurate measures." *Frontiers in Psychology* 12: 715843.

Culture is a good prior, not a label

Every Individual is at an intersection of multiple overlapping cultures.

People from the same country, religion, gender, generation, or linguistic group do not behave identically.

Cultural information can help provide useful context, but treating demographic categories as deterministic can also reinforce stereotypes.



The Bender Rule, and beyond

Bender Rule:

1. Explicitly state which language(s) your work studies.
2. Avoid implicitly treating English as the default or universal language.

Extend the same principle beyond language.

1. Explicitly state: varieties, geographical and cultural context, intended population
2. Explicitly state your fairness definition: For instance, what fairness criterion allows averaging performance metrics across languages to determine the optimal model, if and when average is used.

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Closing

By all presenters

Call to Action

Ethics is a necessary long-term conversation that all of us need to participate in.

- Reinforce our community's **ethics review community!** Volunteer for ethical reviewing: add your name to the scribing document to help us form a larger ethics reviewing pool. (*Ethics reviewing also lowers your scientific reviewing load!*)

- Add publications you are aware of to the Ethics reading list! https://github.com/acl-org/ethics-reading-list

What Else is Missing?

- Online Reviewing Course by Carolyn Rose and A. Seza Dugroz
  https://proton.oli.cmu.edu/sections/peer_review_course/enroll
  (for more information email: as.dogruoz@ugent.be)